



VALUABLE METALS

Seawater contains dissolved minerals that may form tiny particles. These attract other particles, and over millions of years, they grow into fist-sized lumps that settle on the ocean floor. They contain a variety of valuable metals including manganese, and are known as manganese nodules. But since these nodules form in deep oceans, they are difficult and expensive to harvest—as are the valuable minerals formed by the black smokers that erupt from mid-ocean ridges.



WOW!

Namibia, in southwest Africa, has the richest known resource of marine diamonds in the world.



GLITTERING PRIZES

Off the southwest coast of Africa, diamonds are mined from the sea. These gemstones were originally formed in rocks on land, which have weathered over time. The diamonds were eventually carried down rivers to the coast, where they are found scattered among the gravel of the shallow seabed. Dredged up by special ships, and then separated from the gravel, many have the eight-sided form of perfect diamond crystals.

SAND AND GRAVEL

All over the world, huge quantities of sand and gravel are scooped from shallow seabeds, shipped back to shore, and unloaded, as seen here. These materials are used for making concrete and other building materials, and for road construction. The sand is also used for glass-making, because it is often pure quartz—the main ingredient of glass.

